

THE SCENE, Elmira, N.Y., Aug. 13, 1972



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Elmira was on the threshold of its greatest baseball days — on the playing field, not at the gate.

Oriole farmhands gave Elmira seven straight first division clubs — including pennant winners in 1964 and in 1966 by an all-time Eastern League 20½-game spread and a divisional champ in 1967.

Fans turned out to the tune of 92,508 (including playoffs) in 1962, but gates dwindled each year since to a 37-year Elmira low of 51,907 in 1970 for a last-place club.

A year later (1971) when the Pioneers won the pennant, the attendance was 52,949 — a difference of only 1,042 customers.

The Orioles, complaining about loss of money, absence of local interest and, once again poor press relations, turned back the franchise after the 1968 season.

Again local people found another agreement with two expansion clubs — San Diego and Kansas City.

The 1969 team was a good one, featuring Jerry Morales and Fred Kendall. Elmira finished third but couldn't draw.

Elmira officials continued to hold the reins through the 1970 season, when Kansas City (and Lou Gorman) took over the agreement. KC provided a poor team (Elmira finished last for the first time since 1932) and an inexperienced general manager, and the gate slipped to a 37-year low.

The Elmira group kept losing money and pleaded with Gorman and Kansas City to take over ownership and run the show.

Gorman agreed and took over the Pioneers in November 1970.

The Pioneers name was changed to Royals, and KC sent in a top manager (Harry Malmberg) and a host of standout players. All KC didn't give Elmira was a promotion-minded general manager.

So the 1971 champs drew only 52,949, and Gorman claimed KC lost too much money. The Royals exited.

This time two young men from Cleveland, Kip Horsburgh and Carl Fazio, in their second season of pro baseball, picked up the Elmira franchise. They got Cleveland to provide player talent. Then they went out, picked up the pieces of poor promotion of the past and had the Twins Tiers area once again talking baseball.

Now, it's all kaput because of a poor team plus the disastrous flood of '72.

Monday's anniversary celebration is aimed at helping the Pioneer owners recoup something in what looms as a big losing year.

